State of the Practice for Open-Source Neural Network Software

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Abstract

Open-source neural network (NN) software plays an important role in modern AI research and development. Assessing the software-engineering practices of NN packages, however, is challenging because relevant evidence is distributed across public artifacts such as documentation, tests, issue trackers, releases, and continuous integration (CI) configurations.

This paper presents DomainX, a tool-supported workflow for conducting a state-of-practice assessment of open-source NN software based on a published methodology. DomainX supports evidence capture, scoring through a measurement template spanning nine software-quality attributes, incorporation of repository-based measures, and overall comparison using the Analytic Hierarchy Process (AHP).

We apply this workflow to a curated shortlist of 28 open-source NN software packages and produce a traceable dataset containing template responses, repository-based measures, and package-level references (project website and repository URLs). **[RESULTS SUMMARY TO BE ADDED AFTER FINAL RANKING IS CONFIRMED.]** A companion repository provides the DomainX tool and associated assessment artifacts to support review and reuse.

Keywords: state of practice; research software; neural network libraries; software quality; measurement template; Analytic Hierarchy Process (AHP); traceability; reproducibility; repository mining.

1. Introduction

Research and engineering outcomes increasingly depend on software, and the quality of that software affects reliability, maintainability, and reproducibility. In domains where open-source libraries are widely reused, understanding current development practice is an important step toward improving it. A *state-of-practice* assessment provides a structured way to characterize what developers commonly do in a domain by evaluating representative software packages against explicit software-quality criteria using traceable evidence.

Conducting such assessments rigorously is challenging in practice. Evidence relevant to software quality is distributed across many public artifacts, including documentation, tutorials, repository history, tests, issue trackers, releases, and continuous integration (CI) configurations. This makes the assessment process time-consuming and creates challenges for auditability, maintenance, and reproducibility as repositories evolve over time.

This paper presents a tool-supported state-of-practice assessment for *neural network (NN) software*. The target audience is developers and maintainers of NN software; accordingly, the scope is restricted to NN packages rather than general-purpose NN-supporting libraries from adjacent communities. The assessment workflow follows a published state-of-practice methodology based on (i) a measurement template organized by software-quality attributes, (ii)

repository-based measures extracted from public repositories, and (iii) an Analytic Hierarchy Process (AHP) ranking procedure to combine evidence into transparent comparisons.

The contributions of this work are:

- A curated shortlist of 28 open-source NN software packages evaluated using a consistent, evidence-based procedure (Appendix Appendix A).
- A traceable assessment dataset recording measurement-template responses, repository-based measures, and package-level references (project website and repository URLs) for auditability and reuse.
- DomainX, a tool that supports evidence capture, scoring, ranking computations, and export of results to reduce manual effort and improve traceability (`https://github.com/thaafei/DomainX`).

The remainder of this paper defines key concepts and summarizes background (Section 2), describes the assessment methodology and tool support (Section 3), and reports results and observations from applying the approach to the shortlisted packages (Section 4). The paper concludes with discussion, recommendations, and limitations (Sections 5–7).

2. Background and Definitions

In this paper, *research software* refers to software used to support scientific or engineering work such as data processing, model training or inference, experimentation, and analysis. A *domain* is a coherent problem area characterized by shared goals and typical workflows; in a state-of-practice assessment, the domain determines which software packages are relevant and what evidence is meaningful for evaluation. A *library* (or package) is a reusable software component intended to be integrated into other programs. We use *evidence* to mean publicly available artifacts that indicate software-development practice, including documentation and tutorials, repository history (commits and releases), issue trackers and pull requests, tests, and continuous integration (CI) configurations.

The *state of the art* describes the most advanced methods and recommended best practices reported in research and practitioner literature. The *state of practice* describes what is commonly done in real projects: the tools used, the artifacts produced, and the quality-related practices that are routinely applied. Gaps between state of the art and state of practice are common, particularly in research settings where incentives and timelines may prioritize functionality and novelty over long-term maintainability, transparency, or reproducibility. A state-of-practice assessment aims to characterize this reality using explicit criteria and traceable evidence, enabling systematic comparison and targeted recommendations.

A published state-of-practice methodology guides our assessment by combining (i) a measurement template grounded in software-quality attributes with (ii) evidence extracted from public artifacts and repository-based measures, enabling comparisons that are intended to be reproducible and auditable Smith et al. (October 2021).

To produce an overall comparison across multiple criteria, we use the Analytic Hierarchy Process (AHP), a multi-criteria decision-making method that derives weights from pairwise comparisons of criteria and aggregates scores accordingly. AHP is well suited to this setting because it makes weighting assumptions explicit and supports transparent trade-offs among software-quality attributes. In this work, AHP is used to compute an evidence-based ranking and to support sensitivity analysis on how rankings change under different weighting choices.

3. Methods

3.1. Domain framing and scope

Neural network (NN) software is defined here as open-source libraries whose primary purpose is to enable the development, training, deployment, analysis, or direct use of neural network models. The target audience for this assessment is developers and maintainers of NN software. Accordingly, general-purpose NN-supporting packages (e.g., numerical computing, data manipulation, or plotting libraries) are out of scope because they belong to different developer communities and would confound interpretation of NN software development practice. Packages are included when they have a publicly accessible repository and sufficient publicly available artifacts (e.g., documentation and repository history) to support evidence-based evaluation.

3.2. Candidate identification and filtering

Candidate packages were compiled by aggregating package names from authoritative sources and normalizing duplicates and naming variants. To align the assessment with the intended audience, packages that were NN-supporting rather than NN software were removed. Following supervisor guidance, NN software packages were retained even when they appeared only once across the authoritative sources to prioritize completeness of coverage. The final shortlist contains 28 packages. The full shortlist and excluded candidates (with brief reasons) are provided in Appendix Appendix A.

3.3. Evidence sources and data collection

Evidence was derived from publicly available artifacts associated with each package, including documentation (e.g., README and installation guides), tutorials/examples, repository history, releases, issue trackers and pull requests, tests, and continuous integration (CI) configuration when available. Repository-based measures were extracted using automated scripts/tools. Some measurement-template questions required manual judgment (e.g., installation and usage guidance, presence of tests, or CI configuration). Responses were recorded directly in the measurement template, and each package entry includes a project website URL and a source-code repository URL that can be used to verify the recorded responses against the corresponding public artifacts.

3.4. Measurement template and scoring

The assessment uses a published measurement template organized by software-quality attributes. The qualities assessed are: installability; correctness and verifiability; surface reliability; surface robustness; surface usability; maintainability; reusability; surface understandability; and visibility/transparency. For each package, publicly available evidence was used to answer template questions and derive per-quality scores according to the template's scoring rules. Scores were normalized and aggregated to support cross-package comparison. When evidence was missing or ambiguous, responses were recorded conservatively and flagged for traceability.

3.5. Repository-based measures

Repository-based measures complement the measurement template by capturing observable project characteristics and development activity from public repositories. Using the same repository-measure framework defined in the methodology paper, the collected raw data includes GitHub-derived measures such as stars, forks, watchers, open and closed pull requests,

and open and closed issues, together with repository statistics such as number of developers, programming languages, file counts, lines of code, comment lines, blank lines, binary files, total commits, and commit activity over recent yearly and monthly intervals Smith et al. (October 2021). The methodology identifies `git_stats` and `scc` as the tools used to collect repository statistics, with GitHub repository data used when the project is hosted on GitHub Smith et al. (October 2021).

In addition to raw measures, the methodology defines a small set of processed measures derived from the raw data. These include project status (alive or dead), percentage of issues closed, and percentage of code that is comments Smith et al. (October 2021). Together, these measures provide additional context for interpreting the quality scores recorded in the measurement template.

3.6. Ranking method (AHP) and sensitivity analysis

To produce an overall comparison across multiple quality criteria, this work uses the Analytic Hierarchy Process (AHP), following the methodology paper Smith et al. (October 2021). AHP is a multi-criteria decision-making technique based on pairwise comparisons. In this context, it is used to compare software packages using the quality scores derived from the measurement template. The pairwise comparisons are used to construct matrices that yield an overall score for each package under the selected criteria weights Smith et al. (October 2021).

As emphasized in the methodology, the ranking is not meant to identify a single universally "best" package. Instead, it is intended to provide insight into the top-performing set of packages and to support interpretation of domain-wide patterns Smith et al. (October 2021). The methodology also includes sensitivity analysis so that the stability of the ranking can be examined under uncertainty or variation in the quality scores and weighting choices Smith et al. (October 2021).

3.7. Tool support: DomainX

DomainX supports a tool-based workflow for conducting the assessment and managing the resulting dataset. It provides an interactive interface for recording measurement-template responses and repository-based measures across the shortlisted packages. DomainX also integrates the Analytic Hierarchy Process (AHP) computation used to aggregate quality-level scores into an overall comparison and visualizes the resulting ranking. In addition, the tool supports export of assessment artifacts for reporting and review. The DomainX implementation is available at `https://github.com/thaafei/DomainX`.

Figure 1: DomainX graph view illustrating the overall AHP ranking for the assessed packages.

3.8. Environment and reproducibility

Following the methodology, installation-based assessment is performed in a clean, isolated environment so that software packages are evaluated on a more level playing field Smith et al. (October 2021). The methodology recommends using virtual machines (VMs) because they provide a fresh environment for each installation attempt, reduce conflicts with pre-existing libraries, and help avoid "works-on-my-computer" effects Smith et al. (October 2021).

In the methodology, repository-based data is collected first, followed by installation and measurement-template scoring. The methodology also recommends recording environment details for each installation context, including the operating system and virtualization environment, to support repeatability Smith et al. (October 2021). In the present work, some older packages required additional environment setup because their dependencies and installation requirements were not readily compatible with a modern default environment. In these cases, containerized environments defined through Dockerfiles were used to reproduce a more suitable setup and improve consistency across installation attempts. These choices were made to improve consistency and transparency of the assessment process.

4. Results

4.1. Descriptive summary of assessed packages

Summarize the evaluated set (final no., alive/dead counts, languages/activity/licensing if reported). Present statistics that help give insight into the domain landscape before ranking.

4.2. Overall ranking

the final ranking table and a short explanation of how to read it. Highlight top-ranked packages without overconfidence/ overdoing it. Reference DomainX ranking output as a figure/table.

4.3. Quality-by-quality breakdown

results by quality attribute (tables/figures). Identify strong/weak packages per quality and report domain-wide patterns supported by evidence.

4.4. Sensitivity analysis

how rankings change under weight variation, identify stable vs unstable parts of the ranking and summary of implications.

4.5. Popularity vs evidence-based ranking (optional)

Compare evidence-based results against reputation indicators (e.g. stars/download). Discuss alignment/misalignment and what it suggests about state-of-practice versus popularity.

5. Discussion and Recommendations

what the results imply for users and maintainers. actionable recommendations organized by quality attribute (installability, maintainability, transparency...). Keep recommendations evidence-backed.

6. Threats to Validity and Limitations

construct validity, internal validity, external validity, and temporal validity. Note limitations such as evolving repositories, subjectivity in scoring, missing/ambiguous evidence, and interviews not conducted yet.

7. Conclusion and Future Work

Summarize contributions (DomainX + dataset + findings), key results, list future work (interviews, expanded shortlist, stronger sensitivity analysis, refined scoring rules, deeper automation).

Appendix A. Assessed packages and exclusions

table listing all assessed packages and excluded candidates with brief reasons to help traceability.

Appendix B. Measurement template excerpt and scoring rules

compact excerpt of measurement template and key scoring/normalization rules, or provide link to full template.

Appendix C. AHP weights and matrices

final AHP weights and any matrices needed for transparency and reproducibility.

Appendix D. DomainX screenshots and exported artifacts

potential figures: ranking view, table view, metric editing view, export example.

References

Spencer Smith, Jacques Carette, Peter Michalski, Ao Dong, and Olu Owojaiye. Methodology for assessing the state of the practice for domain x. *arXiv preprint arXiv:2110.11575v1*, abs/2110.11575:1–15, October 2021. URL `https://arxiv.org/abs/2110.11575`.